

Auwa Book

Last Updated: 11 August 2026 — publishing route decided and the first approaches sent. See PUBLISHING ROUTE below before proposing anything about how the books reach readers.

THE BOOKS ARE NOW THE FOUNDATION (5 August 2026)

The three-pillar pivot changed this pillar's status more than any other. The app is parked; Auwa is a character IP business with a Japan practice attached; and **everything downstream — the figure, the collaboration editions, the exhibition route, eventual licensing — depends on the character becoming known.** Publishing these books properly is therefore the single highest-leverage act available to Auwa, and it outranks almost everything else on the to-do list.

Which reweights the publisher question. When the app was the flagship, self-publishing was fine, because the character only had to serve app users. It no longer is. A publisher offers bookshop distribution, foreign rights and review coverage that cannot be bought at any price, and those are precisely the levers on making a character known. **Settled 11 August 2026: try the publisher route properly, on a deadline, with IngramSpark and Amazon KDP as the fallback that needs nobody's permission.** Full reasoning, the contacts approached, and the steps in order are in PUBLISHING ROUTE below.

Releasing Books 1 and 2 as a set is now more important than ever: two books read as a *series*, which is a materially stronger proposition to a publisher, to press, and to a Japanese maker opening a parcel.

Second job these books do. The printed book is the physical calling card for Japan. Craftsman outreach is gated on it existing, because a maker who has spent forty years on one craft will take a beautiful printed book seriously and a website link not at all. What goes in the parcel: both books, a figure, and a one-page Japanese profile of Auwa and of Rieko as its creator.

See `context/business/business.md` 6.4 and 6.2a, and `CLAUDE.md` → THE PIVOT.

STATUS SNAPSHOT (11 August 2026)

Books 1 and 2 are **both finished** and Rieko is saving out the final files with the July amends applied. They **release together as a set**, not Book 1 alone. Page counts are settled and correct. Print-ready PDFs live in `Dropbox/3 venture/auwa/production/book/Indesign/_indesign/_pdf/_pdf_pages/`.

Series titles (settled 12 August 2026)

English edition: Dawn, Ocean, Humans, Lioma. Four bare single-word nouns, no articles.

Book	English	Was
01	Dawn	The Beginning
02	Ocean	Umi
03	Humans	Human
04	Lioma	(unchanged)

Why Dawn for Book 1. Rieko wanted Book 1 to keep the *meaning* of "The Beginning" rather than name its setting, and she wanted the Japanese edition to carry that meaning too rather than a word for Earth. Dawn does it in one bare noun: it means a beginning without being abstract, and it is made of light, which is what Auwa is and how it arrives, so the title does double work. It also translates well. あけぼの (**akebono**) is the poetic word for dawn and opens Sei Shōnagon's *Pillow Book* with 春はあけぼの; 夜明け (**yoake**) is the plainer option. *Origin* and *Arrival* were the runners-up; *Arrival* was set aside because a luminous telepathic being arriving on Earth sits uncomfortably close to the 2016 film.

Humans, not Human. Bare "Human" reads adjectivally before it reads as a noun, and can mean the abstract quality rather than the beings. "Humans" is concrete, matches the other three as nouns, and matches the book, where Auwa meets many of them.

Japanese edition keeps Japanese titles, Umi among them. Rieko is translating now. This is the normal publishing split and nothing is lost: Umi reads naturally on a Japanese cover and gives an English-reading bookseller nothing to work with. Reversed on 12 Aug from the 11 Aug decision to use Umi in English.

Why bare nouns. The set had no naming system: one English abstract, one Japanese noun, one English noun, one invented one, which reads as four separate decisions rather than a series. All-bare fixes it and makes Lioma sit naturally, because everything is a bare noun and one of them simply happens to be a place. "The Beginning" could not survive the articles being dropped ("Beginning" alone reads as a participle), so Book 1 became **Earth**, which the /book section

heading already named. It also maps the arc cleanly: Earth, the ocean within it, the humans on it, then off the planet entirely.

Lioma stays a proper noun. It is a planet in the WAWA system where the Maon live (see `business.md`), so unlike Umi it has no English equivalent being withheld. Invented place names are native to children's books.

Release order is NOT locked. The plan is both books as a pair, which is Rieko's preference and the stronger proposition, but a publisher may want them released singly and that is their call. **Keep public copy neutral on this.** The journal CTA was rewritten on 12 Aug from "the first illustrated story" to "where the illustrated stories begin" for exactly this reason. Do not reintroduce copy that presumes either release pattern.

Still to change: the cover artwork still reads "The Beginning" and "Umi", so both need redrawing before print. The journal article *titled* "The Beginning" is Rieko's origin essay, a different thing, and keeps its name.

Rieko kept the repeated "we are all connected" message in Reco's speech deliberately (see EDITORIAL FEEDBACK below).

PUBLISHING ROUTE (decided 11 August 2026)

The decision: try a publisher properly, on a deadline, with print-on-demand as the fallback that needs nobody's permission. Approaches went out on 11 August. Decision date is **31 January 2027**. If nothing has landed by then, the books go to IngramSpark and Amazon KDP and the question is closed.

Why a publisher rather than self-publishing

The bottleneck is not distribution. Anyone can put a book on Amazon in a week. The bottleneck is that **nobody knows the character**, and the entire business downstream (the figure, the collab editions, the exhibition route, any eventual licensing) depends on fixing that. A publisher supplies the three things that cannot be bought at any price: bookshop distribution, review coverage, and foreign rights, especially into Japan. Those are precisely the levers on making a character known.

Self-publishing solves the wrong problem well. It gets the book available and does close to nothing for discovery.

And the order matters, which is the part that is easy to get wrong. Self-publishing first and "going to a publisher later from a position of strength" is sound advice for business and non-fiction books and poor advice for picture books. A picture book with a visible trade sales history of a couple of hundred copies is harder to sell to an editor than an unpublished one, because the debut has been spent and there is now a disappointing number in the room. The publisher attempt has to come first or not at all.

Why the IP fear is overstated

This was the main worry going in, and it does not survive contact with how these contracts actually work.

A publishing contract **licenses publishing rights** in named territories and languages. It does not transfer copyright and it cannot touch registered trademarks. Auwa's marks already exist across classes 16, 20, 25, 28, 35 and 41, they predate any deal, and the figure is already in production. No publisher acquires any of that by signing a book deal.

What a standard contract *does* often ask for is a subsidiary rights clause covering merchandising and character licensing. That is a negotiable line item, routinely carved out for author-illustrators, and if a publisher will not carve it, walk. Publishers are genuinely interested in the books alone; that is the normal shape of a picture book deal.

The merchandising carve-out protects more than the figure. Restated 12 Aug 2026: a publisher holding merchandising and character rights would block not only the figure but any future art-toy licensing deal (Medicom, Pop Mart and similar), which is a live 2028 possibility. This is not a theoretical clause to trade away for a better advance. Say so explicitly to whoever reviews the contract.

Contract should be with More Air Limited, not Auwa Limited. An advance paid to Auwa Ltd would end its dormancy, which Tom has decided against (see `structure.md`). More Air holds an exclusive licence with an express sub-licensing right and a term running to 2036 following the 12 Aug 2026 variation, so it can grant publishing rights cleanly and will survive a publisher's due diligence.

Three clauses to check if an offer comes. Merchandising and character rights struck out entirely, so the figure and future collaborations stay wholly Auwa's. Any option clause limited to a first look at the next Auwa picture book and nothing wider. A reversion clause so rights return if the book goes out of print. Use the Society of Authors contract review, which is free to members and around £120 a year to join, or a publishing solicitor.

What it costs to try

Roughly four months of calendar time and a handful of emails. That is the entire downside, because IngramSpark can be executed at any point afterwards and requires no permission from anyone.

The real cost is the timeline, and it should be stated plainly. Picture books are scheduled eighteen to twenty-four months ahead. A deal in mid-2027 means publication in 2028 or 2029. That is survivable only because nothing else in the plan waits on it: author copies from POD, or a short run, can supply the Japan calling card independently at any time.

Honest framing. This is not "definitely better" in the sense of guaranteed. It is a cheap, time-boxed test with unusually good access, and skipping it is the expensive choice because it cannot be reversed later.

The access, which is what makes this worth doing

Cold picture book submissions from unknowns get about forty seconds of attention. A book that arrives through a name gets read properly. Tom's contacts here are unusually strong for a debut and are the single biggest argument for the publisher route:

- **Dominic Brendon** (cousin) — **currently Senior Key Account Manager at HarperCollins, on maternity cover.** Previously UK Sales Director for Online and Digital at Simon & Schuster UK, Aug 2007 to Jan 2025, seventeen and a half years. The most valuable person on the list. Sales sits in the room when a house decides whether to acquire, so his read on saleability is close to the read a publisher would give. Also has a Japanese wife, which Piers rates as making him unusually well placed to judge whether Auwa travels to a non-Japanese readership. **Emailed 11 Aug 2026. Replied 12 Aug offering to share the books with the children's specialists at HarperCollins; Tom said yes the same morning.**
 - **Two things to read correctly.** The maternity cover means his HarperCollins access has an end date, so anything that needs to happen inside that building should happen now rather than in three months. And he is sales, not editorial, so an internal pass to colleagues is warm but is not an editor championing the book.
 - **The second ask, if HarperCollins passes, is Simon & Schuster,** where seventeen years of relationships actually sit. Do not spend both asks at once.
- **Colin Midson** (book PR, ex-Simon & Schuster) — ran PR on Tom's mother's translation *I Chose the Storm*, which self-published, was featured in the Sunday Telegraph, sat in the Amazon top ten and sold nearly three thousand copies. Placed the Damien Lewis

endorsement on it. **Emailed 11 Aug 2026**, asking for a publishability read, a blurb approach, press potential, and whether he would work on it (paid).

- **Piers Brendon** (cousin) — historian, former Keeper of the Churchill Archives Centre. Asked narrowly for an agent introduction. **Emailed 11 Aug 2026. Replied 12 Aug:** called the book "beautiful and magical" and wants to help, but has no children's-literature expertise, his own agent has retired, and John Burningham is dead (Helen Oxenbury alive but not contactable). **Offered to forward to Stephanie Nettell**, who edited the Guardian's children's books coverage for many years and retains publisher and writer contacts through the King's Lynn literary festival. He is waiting on Tom's yes before forwarding. Rates Dom as the better bet.
 - **Nettell's real value is not contacts, it is the read.** She is the first person in this chain who can assess the books *as children's literature*. Nobody else approached can do that.
- **Jay Elwes** (cousin) — Deputy Editor, The New World; formerly TheArticle and Prospect. **Held deliberately.** His ask is the vaguest of the four and a vague question gets a vague answer. Approach once the others reply and there is a specific need, most likely press or a named writer on illustration or Japan.
- **Damien Lewis** — bestselling author, blurbed *I Chose the Storm*, and Tom introduced him to family which led to his writing about Tom's grandfather. **Held.** A thriller and military-history author endorsing a picture book would sit oddly, so his value is an introduction rather than a blurb. Save the favour until it is clear what to ask for.

Blurbs go on the submission, not after it

Corrected from an earlier draft of this plan, on Tom's experience with *I Chose the Storm*, where the endorsement was secured early and was decisive. An endorsement from a recognisable name is the thing most likely to get an editor to read past the first spread.

Yes, picture books carry endorsements, usually on the back cover or inside flap. Best candidates, in order:

1. **Beth Kempton** — wrote *Wabi Sabi* and *Kokoro*, speaks to exactly this audience, and is the most likely yes.
2. **Ken Mogi** — the ikigai books.
3. **Robert Macfarlane** — long shot, but *The Lost Words* is the nearest precedent for an illustrated book carrying philosophy.
4. **Jackie Morris** and other picture book illustrators.

It is a warm-introduction game, which is what Colin is good at.

How to approach Beth Kempton

Only if Colin passes on handling endorsements. If he takes it on, he goes through her agent and none of this applies.

Her contact page states her filter openly, which is the most useful thing on it: she "rarely responds to unsolicited emails, unless it is relating to an opportunity that will help me reach more people with my work." Build the approach around that sentence.

Routes available (bethkempton.com/contact):

- learning@dowhatyouloveforlife.com — courses, mentoring, speaking and podcasts.
- **Her agent** — rights enquiries. Email is obfuscated on the page. Slightly the wrong address for an endorsement, since agents handle translation and licensing, so a blurb request lands there as business and gets the slowest, coldest treatment.
- **Instagram @bethkempton** — where she says she is active when not writing.

The recommended route: Rieko, on Instagram, after she has read *Kokoro*, with no ask in the first message. A genuine response to the book from a Japanese illustrator, and who she is. That is precisely what Beth's stated filter is designed to let through, and Rieko's account speaks for itself in a way an email signature cannot. The blurb becomes the second conversation, by which point it is not cold.

Bring something rather than ask for something. An Auwa Journal piece or interview with her, published on auwa.life, is literally "an opportunity that will help me reach more people with my work." This is the same principle already written into the craftsman outreach plan: the first approach is never "will you give us something," it is "may we tell your story."

Why this is genuinely good for her, not a favour. A British author writing about Japanese ideas for a Western audience will field the appropriation question forever. A Japanese creator engaging seriously with her work, and a Japanese-authored book she can point to, is real validation. **Do not say this out loud in the approach.** Let it be obvious.

One thing to handle openly. Kempton has a book called *Kokoro* and Auwa uses *Kokoro* as its central word. Not a problem, it is a common Japanese word nobody owns and Rieko's use goes back a decade, but the overlap is close enough that the approach should acknowledge her book directly rather than write around it. Handled well it is the reason she says yes.

Publisher targets if no introduction materialises

Independents that suit this register and take direct submissions: **Flying Eye Books**, **Enchanted Lion** (New York, literary and quiet, arguably the best single fit), **Templar**, **Walker Books**, **Thames & Hudson**. Plus three or four children's agents found through the Writers' and Artists' Yearbook, since an agent is the only route into the big houses.

And separately, Rieko writing in Japanese to Fukuinkan Shoten, Kaisei-sha and Bronze Publishing. This may well be the faster yes. She is Japanese, the books come out of her own culture, and a Japanese publisher strengthens the whole Japan practice in a way a British one would not. Do not treat this as a secondary track.

Submit in **October**. UK publishing is largely shut through August, and September is the backlog.

Territories, Japanese rights, and the trademark

Rieko can publish separately in Japan, but only if the contract is negotiated for it.

Picture book deals grant rights in named territories and languages, and the two usual shapes are very different:

- *World rights, all languages.* The publisher controls translation, sells Japanese rights to a house of their choosing, and passes a share back. Rieko would have no say in which Japanese publisher takes it.
- *UK and Commonwealth, English language only.* Japanese rights stay with Auwa entirely and Rieko does her own deal with whoever she wants.

So the ask is to retain Japanese language rights, or all translation rights. For an illustrated book by a Japanese author with her own relationships, that is reasonable and winnable.

It is not free, though, and the reason publishers resist is legitimate rather than greedy: picture books are **co-printed**, one large run across several languages, which is what makes the unit economics work, and translation sales are a real part of the income. Carving out Japanese may cost something elsewhere in the deal. Worth paying here, because Japan is strategic for Auwa in a way it would not be for an ordinary author.

Order matters too. A Japanese deal landing *first* is fine and can help rather than hurt. A book already published in Japan is easier to sell to a UK house, and there is no conflict while territories do not overlap. Another reason the Japanese publishers are not a second-string track.

The trademark does not complicate a deal. Class 16 covers books, printed matter and illustrations. Owning it does not block a publisher; the contract itself grants them permission.

What it does is stop anyone else putting the Auwa name on books, and stop a publisher spinning off Auwa-branded printed goods (posters, stationery) without agreement. A publisher will want a licence to use the name and mark for publishing and promoting the book, which is normal. **Do not grant an assignment of the mark, or any licence wider than the book.**

Two things to settle with the accountant before an offer arrives, both from `context/business/structure.md` :

1. **Who signs.** Copyright in the illustrations was assigned from Rieko and Tom personally to Auwa Limited on 23 February 2026. Rieko is the author; **Auwa Limited is the rights holder**. Publishers ask the signatory to warrant they own the rights, so the contracting party is the company with Rieko named as author and illustrator. Get this right on the paperwork rather than unpicking it later.
2. **Dormancy.** Auwa Limited is dormant, and an advance or royalties paid into it would end that and trigger tax filings. Auwa Ltd already grants More Air an exclusive worldwide licence with sublicensing permitted, so the cleaner route is probably for **More Air to grant the publishing sublicense and receive the income**. An accountant question, but far better asked now than in the week an offer lands.

Does the wider brand help or hurt the pitch?

Net positive, but the framing is load-bearing and easy to get wrong.

What helps. It proves Rieko is serious and will still be here in three years, which is a genuine editorial anxiety. It shows a world rather than a one-off, so a series is credible. The journal proves the Japanese material is lived rather than decorative, and Rieko being Japanese answers the appropriation question before anyone asks it. The Awwwards Honorable Mention is a concrete third-party credential. And publishers increasingly expect authors to help market.

What hurts. The real risk is reading as **a brand looking for a book rather than a book**. Editors are wary of picture books acquired as brand extensions, because they mostly do not work. Secondary risk: trademarks, a figure and collaboration plans quietly signal that the merchandising upside is already off the table, and some houses acquire partly for that. And the Instagram following is small by publishing standards, where a platform barely counts below five figures, so mention it lightly rather than presenting it as an asset.

Therefore, in any submission letter: the books come first and take most of the space. The brand goes in one short paragraph at the end, as evidence of commitment. **Do not mention licensing ambitions at all, and do not raise the merchandising carve-out until there is an offer on the table.**

This is why the 11 Aug emails differ by recipient: Dominic's kept the brand to a footnote, Colin's led with it. A PR's job is to find the story; an editor's job is to fall for the book.

The fallback, in full

If 31 January passes with nothing:

- Buy ISBNs from **Nielsen** (a block of 10, around £160), registered to Auwa Limited so Auwa is the publisher. **Do not buy them before this point** — a publisher assigns its own and yours go unused.
- Upload both books to **IngramSpark** (hardback, 10x8 landscape, premium colour). Set the wholesale discount to 55% and mark them returnable, which is what makes bookshops willing to order. Ingram is the wholesaler physical shops actually buy through.
- Upload to **Amazon KDP** for Amazon, and turn Amazon *off* in Ingram's channels to avoid duplicate listings.
- Price at ordinary trade level, around **£14.99 each**. See the pricing correction below.
- Order author copies only when the files are final including any blurb. No minimum, no deadline, so there is no reason to commit early.

Print-on-demand means no stock, no packing, no posting, and no possibility of dead inventory. That directly answers Tom's constraint. It is also why the earlier idea in this session of a pre-order-funded litho run was dropped.

Pricing correction (11 August 2026)

An earlier version of this session's advice priced a signed set at £75-85. That was wrong and was walked back. Signed and numbered raises the price of something people already want; it does not create wanting. A signature is worth money when the name means something, and Rieko's does not yet outside the household. Two picture books are two picture books, and the going rate for a good hardback is £13-16.

The premium logic belongs to the figure, not the book. Art toys have collector culture, a display object and a real comparison set at £60-200, so 25 hand-finished numbered pieces at a high price is entirely coherent. Applying the same logic to picture books is not. Do not conflate them.

At this stage **a copy in someone's hands is worth more than the margin on a copy that did not sell**, because the whole business depends on the character becoming known.

Shopify and the book

Neither IngramSpark nor Amazon KDP integrates with Shopify. The norm for small publishers, and the recommendation here, is a product page on auwa.life with buttons out to Amazon and Bookshop.org. If direct sales later matter, **Lulu Direct** is the Shopify app that prints and ships automatically, used alongside Ingram for the trade. Don't build that second system at launch.

The Shopify store for the figure and prints is **not blocked by any of this** and can be built at any time.

Next steps, in order

1. Wait on Dom, Colin and Piers. Chase gently after two weeks of silence.
2. ~~Make Umi the title everywhere.~~ **Superseded 12 Aug** by the bare-noun set (see SERIES TITLES above). The /book page and the remaining site copy are done and deployed.
Outstanding: the cover artwork, which still reads "The Beginning" and "Umi" and needs redrawing before print.
3. **Rieko reads Beth Kempton's *Kokoro*.** Ordered 11 Aug 2026. Asking an author to endorse your book when you have not read theirs is the weakest possible approach, and the overlap here is close enough that it would show. Reading it also gives Colin time to reply.
4. **Then approach Beth Kempton**, if Colin has passed on handling endorsements. See HOW TO APPROACH BETH KEMPTON below. The blurb goes on the submission, not after it.
5. **Rieko exports Japanese-language versions of Books 1 and 2.** Needed for the Japanese publishers and for maker outreach later. Submitting in Japanese to Fukuinkan Shoten, Kaisei-sha and Bronze is much stronger than sending English PDFs, and it is the difference between a serious approach and a translated-looking one.
6. **Submit in October**, using whatever introductions and endorsements came back. If none, go direct to the independents listed above, and Rieko to the Japanese houses in Japanese.
7. Email Jay once there is a specific ask.
8. **Decision date: 31 January 2027.**
9. Only then, if nothing landed: Nielsen ISBNs, IngramSpark plus KDP, link out from Shopify, order author copies for Japan and press.

THE FOUR BOOKS

The Auwa illustrated story universe comprises four books, each following Auwa — a luminous being sent from the stars — as it encounters different aspects of Earth and reveals the Kokoro

(heart/soul) hidden within all things.

Book 1: Dawn (*was "The Beginning" until 12 Aug 2026*) — Auwa arrives on Earth, finds a lonely blue flower (Bluu) in a dying forest, reveals her Kokoro through a light shower, restores the forest, and meets the soil microbes who explain that everything is connected. *Status: Complete, further revised, at print test. 44 pages, ~470 words. PDF: [_pdf_pages/AUWA01_8x10.pdf](#). Mockup: [/book/1](#) on the website.*

Book 2: Ocean (*English; Umi on the Japanese edition. See SERIES TITLES above.*) — Auwa explores the ocean, meets a red fish, a yellow coral, and Rai (turtle), cuts loose a drifting ghost net, reaches the Coral Paradise, meets Reco (ancient red coral) and Amo (great whale with her calf Yuki), and hears the sea creatures' stories of humans ("They can be kind" / "They can be cruel" / "We do not understand them yet"). Ends pointing to the human world. *Status: COMPLETE and fully revised (was the old 30-page version needing work). ~540 words, 46 pages preferred. PDF: [_pdf_pages/AUWA02_8x10.pdf](#). Mockup: [/book/2](#) on the website.*

Assessment (July 2026): Book 2 is the stronger book and its revision is a textbook execution of the Book 1 template — no speech bubbles, named minor characters culled, the pollution lecture gone, the ghost net as a wordless visual event. It adds genuine stakes (the human question) and a series engine (Book 3 is now loaded as "the humans" book: land → sea → humans). Releasing the two together turns "a book" into "a series", which is a stronger commercial and PR proposition and lets the two tonal poles (cosmic/dark, aquatic/luminous) show the universe's range.

Book 3: [TBC] — *Status: Not yet reviewed. Book 2's ending sets it up as the humans book.*

Book 4: [TBC] — *Status: Not yet reviewed.*

WHAT THE REVISION ACHIEVES

Book 1 Transformation (the template for all revisions)

The old Book 1 was 30 pages with ~1,200 words. The revised Book 1 is 18 pages with ~380 words. The word count dropped by two-thirds. The emotional impact increased dramatically.

Reference files: Compare [book/1/Auwa_01_0ld.pdf](#) (old, 30 pages) with [book/1/Auwa01_8x10_Compressed.pdf](#) (revised, 18 pages) to see the transformation in full. The old version has speech bubbles, over-explained narration, and a 7-spread

microorganism taxonomy. The new version is tight, atmospheric, and lets the illustrations carry the story.

What was cut:

- Speech bubbles replaced with narration or sparse italicised dialogue
- WAWA planet dialogue (3 spreads of "Did you feel that signal?" chatter → 1 spread)
- Auwa-Earth pleasantries (3 spreads → 1 spread with a single line from Earth)
- Auwa referring to itself in third person ("Auwa is going to Earth!!" → "I'm going to Earth!")
- Microorganism section (7 spreads of exposition → 2 spreads of philosophy)
- The "five kinds of microorganisms" educational taxonomy (cut entirely)
- Copy that described what the illustration already showed

What was kept/strengthened:

- The emotional arc: wonder → arrival → discovery → connection → restoration → deeper truth → onwards
- Bluu's single devastating line: "I feel so lonely"
- The Yaoyorozu no Kami message: "We are all connected, though you cannot see it"
- Key narrative beats that earn their place
- The song lyrics (condensed but preserved)
- Auwa's farewell into the night sky

EDITORIAL FEEDBACK (July 2026 print-test review)

Claude reviewed both print-ready PDFs against the benchmarks. Both pass the core principles (no speech bubbles, sparse italic dialogue, full-bleed emotional peaks). Both run slightly over the ~350-450 word target (Book 1 ~470, Book 2 ~540), which is fine per the "cut what doesn't earn its place, not hit a number" rule. Fixes flagged, all being applied by Rieko EXCEPT the last:

1. **Book 2 set the character's name as "AUWA" (caps) in narration; Book 1 uses "Auwa".** Inconsistent between books and against the brand rule (caps = wordmark only, never prose). Global find-and-replace in Book 2 InDesign. Cover/title-page wordmark treatment unchanged.
2. Book 1 dedication read "for love"; should be "with love" (Book 2 had it right).
3. Book 1, Bluu's thank-you: comma not period before the closing quote.
4. Book 2 dedication spacing ("thesepages") — check InDesign.

5. Terminology: unify "microbes" vs "soil microbes" vs "microorganisms" across the series. Chose **microbes** (warmer, simpler read-aloud).
 6. Book 2: "A great turtle is coming for you" reads faintly ominous; "coming to meet you" keeps the whisper. (Rieko's call.)
 7. **NOT applied — Rieko's deliberate choice.** Suggested trimming Reco's 61-word speech (the "everything is connected" line). Rieko is keeping the repeated connection message on purpose, to emphasise it to the reader; she confirmed with the book-side Claude that repeating it isn't strange. Accepted — the repetition is intentional reinforcement of the core Yaoyorozu no Kami theme, not accidental bloat.
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EDITORIAL PRINCIPLES

These principles apply to all four books. They were established during the Book 1 revision, benchmarked against Matthew Forsythe's *Aggie and the Ghost*, Jon Klassen, and Oliver Jeffers.

Copy restraint

Maximum 2-3 sentences per spread. The old books average 4-6. If a spread has more than 40 words of narration, it's probably too much. The target word count per book is ~350-450 words (Klassen/Forsythe benchmark). That said, not every book needs to land at 18 pages — some stories are naturally longer. The goal is to cut what doesn't earn its place, not to hit an arbitrary page count. If a book needs 22 or 24 pages to tell its story properly, that's fine.

Kill all speech bubbles

The single biggest quality improvement across all books. Rieko's art is painterly, atmospheric, and luminous — hard-edged speech bubbles with dotted borders sit on top of it like UI elements on a watercolour. Every piece of dialogue that matters should be delivered as direct speech within the narration or as standalone italicised text. Bluu saying "I feel so lonely" hits harder as a line of text beneath the image than trapped inside a grey circle.

Show, don't explain

The old copy describes what the images show. The revised copy tells the reader something the image can't — internal feeling, time passing, what a silence sounds like. "Auwa sensed something alive down there" adds to an image of a dark forest. "Auwa descended into the forest" restates it.

Illustrations carry the narrative weight

In Forsythe, the text tells you one thing and the image tells you more. The strongest moments in Auwa work this way already (the colour explosion, the purple sunset). The weakest moments have text restating what the image shows. Cut those restatements.

Dialogue is sparse and character-revealing

Dialogue should reveal character, not move plot mechanics. "Go and see everything for yourself" (Earth's single line) carries more weight than three spreads of pleasantries. Every character gets a voice that sounds different from the narrator's voice — shorter sentences, simpler words, their own personality.

White space and pacing

Alternate between full-bleed image spreads (minimal text) and text-forward pages. This creates breathing room. The emotional peak (Book 1: colour explosion) should be a full-bleed spread with almost no text. The quiet emotional moment (Bluu's loneliness) should have a single line carrying an entire spread.

Cut third-person self-reference in dialogue

Characters should say "I" not their own name. "Yes! I'm going to Earth!" not "Yes! Auwa is going to Earth!!"

Consolidate, don't sequence

If three spreads show the same beat (meeting, greeting, explaining), consolidate to one. The reader doesn't need every step — they need the feeling.

THE BOOK FORMAT

- **Physical size:** 10 x 8 inches landscape (576 x 720 pts in PDF, ratio 4:5 portrait per page)
- **Target page count:** 16-20 pages per book (the Klassen/Jeffers benchmark is ~32 pages including front/back matter, which equals ~16 spreads)
- **Digital format:** Snap-scroll viewer on auwa.life at /book/1, /book/2, etc. Each page fills the viewport. Scroll to advance.

- **Author credit:** Eko Maeda (Rieko's pen name)
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LAYOUT PATTERNS

Each page in the book uses one of these patterns:

Full-bleed with text overlay — Illustration fills the entire page. Text sits on top, usually bottom-left or bottom-centre, with shadow for readability. Used for panoramic scenes (galaxy, sunset, forest, flower field).

Image beside text (split page) — Illustration on one half, text on the other (usually cream/white background for text). Used for dialogue-heavy scenes and character introductions.

Full-bleed dark — Dark atmospheric illustration fills the page with text in light colour. Used for emotional/atmospheric moments (loneliness, night scenes).

Centred minimal — Mostly negative space with a single line of text. Used for key emotional beats ("I feel so lonely").

THE REVISION PROCESS

For each book, the workflow is:

1. **PDF review** — Read the old version, identify the emotional arc, flag what to cut/keep/strengthen
2. **Mockup build** — Render PDF pages as images, create snap-scroll viewer at /book/N on the website
3. **Rieko review** — Rieko scrolls through the mockup, requests copy tweaks and image changes via Claude Code
4. **Iterate** — Claude applies text overlays for copy changes, swaps images, Rieko reviews again
5. **Lock** — Once happy, Rieko updates the final version in InDesign for print

Text changes in the mockup are applied as HTML overlays positioned on top of the page images. Image swaps are done by replacing the page-XX.jpg files. This gives immediate visual feedback without needing to rebuild in InDesign during the review phase.

BOOK 2 SPECIFIC NOTES (PRE-REVISION)

Book 2 (Umi/Ocean) has the same structural issues as old Book 1, likely amplified:

- **Heavy speech bubble dialogue** throughout — multiple characters (Key, Lady, Rai, Reco, Amo) all introduced through speech bubble exchanges
 - **Exposition-heavy** — characters explain ocean pollution, coral bleaching, plastic nets in dialogue. This is the educational tendency that needs to become philosophical.
 - **Too many characters introduced too fast** — Key, Lady, Rai appear in rapid succession with formal introductions
 - **Environmental messaging is didactic** — "These strange objects began appearing in the sea" / "many problems for us and for the ocean's environment" reads like a report, not a story
 - **The emotional arc is buried** — the real story is: Auwa explores, finds beauty damaged, restores it, encounters deeper wisdom about connection. The pollution lecture obscures this.
 - **The dolphin memory sequence** (pages ~24-26) is actually interesting but buried under too much surrounding exposition
 - **Amo the whale** is the strongest emotional presence but arrives too late and gets too little space
 - **The book is 30 pages** — target is ~18 pages (matching Book 1)
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CROSS-BOOK CONTINUITY

- The microorganisms from Book 1 reappear in Book 2 (Reco says "the soil microorganisms told us about you")
- Each book ends with Auwa setting off on the next adventure
- The Kokoro/light shower mechanic is consistent across all books
- Eko Maeda is the author credit on all books
- The "everything is connected" philosophy deepens with each book: land (Book 1) → sea (Book 2) → [TBC] (Book 3) → [TBC] (Book 4)